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**By 2047, we
need to think
of a Viksit
Bharat with
ease of living
and where
businesses are
not harassed
by the state for
compliance**

BUILDING RURAL INDIA

When we talk of Viksit Bharat, we also have to focus on Building Rural India—our BRI—a crucial part of the country

► **REFORM TO PERFORM** and transform with *Jan bhagidaari* is the mantra of government today. We should think in terms of futuristic and transformative reforms when we talk about India in 2047. These reforms should be underpinned on twin-pillars of policy and institution, which in turn can help achieve ease of living for citizens and ease of doing business—the wealth and job creators—over the next 20 odd years.

To achieve ease of living, policies should be formulated to make it easier for citizens to get government services, and not a plethora of schemes and programs, each with competing benefits and complexities in processes. It can be achieved through something as simple as a single sign-on. Why do citizens have to register separately for each scheme of the government—both at a Union and State level.

Similarly, in terms of ease of doing business, we should put in place strong policies under which there is a 15- or 20-point compliance framework for businesses, with which businesses would be expected to comply fully, and any violation would be strictly penalised by the state. This will

guarantee certainty by design and avoid surprises of surveillance and Inspector Raj, a legacy of the British Raj.

This would be a much more efficient system and would also cut down the compliance burden for businesses. For the government, it would mean monitoring violations rather than worrying about which business is complying with which law.

In fact, when we talk about labour reforms, rather than codifying all different laws into four laws and expecting businesses to continue complying with all, the focus should instead be on cutting down the number of labour laws. Protecting jobs is more important than artificially protecting labour. Only a viable enterprise can comply with regulations and pay market wages to workers.

The reduction in the number of rules and going back to the basics is essential. The fear of East India Company must go. Over the years, we have built upon the colonial legacy of rules and regulations, primarily based on distrust of citizens, and that needs to be dismantled. Citizens must have easier access to all services.

We must move to a society where there is equality, an absence of fear and discrimination, and self-